



Google Play Release Guide

Everything left between the built app and a public listing — in the order it has to happen, with the parts that fail silently called out.

Package org.nellab.yno

Version 1.0.0 (versionCode 1)

Bundle build/app/outputs/bundle/release/app-release.aab — 46.8 MB, signed

Account type Personal — closed testing is mandatory

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0 Where things stand

No code work is left. Everything below happens in Play Console and in your own accounts.

Item	Status
App builds, signed release bundle	Done
Package name <code>org.nellab.yno</code>	Done
Launcher icon + app label “YNO”	Done
Store icon 512×512	Done — <code>assets/icon/yno_store_512.png</code>
Privacy policy + terms, publicly reachable	Done — verified live
targetSdk 36 (meets Play’s requirement)	Done
Keystore backed up off-machine	Done
Developer account paid	Done
Feature graphic 1024×500	Missing
Phone screenshots (2 minimum)	Missing
Test account for reviewers	Missing
12+ testers recruited	Missing

The schedule is set by one thing

A **personal** developer account must run a closed test with **12 testers for 14 continuous days** before it may even apply for production. Nothing shortens this. Start recruiting on day one and do the listing work while the clock runs.

1 Create the app

Play Console → All apps → Create app

- 1 App name: **YNO** (max 30 characters — this is what shows on the listing).
- 2 Default language, then **App** (not Game).
- 3 Choose **Free**.
- 4 Accept the declarations and press **Create app**.

Free vs Paid is close to irreversible

A free app can never be switched to paid once it has been published. (Paid → free is allowed, once.) If YNO might ever be paid, that decision has to be made here, not later.

2 App content

[Policy](#) → [App content](#)

A checklist of declarations. Every one must be green before you can release to any track — including closed testing.

Section	What to enter
Privacy policy	https://nellab.org/app/privacy
Ads	No, the app does not contain ads
App access	Restricted — supply credentials (see below)
Content rating	Questionnaire; a sports organiser rates very low
Target audience	13+ or 16+. Do not tick under-13
Data safety	Email, name, photos, contacts (see below)
Government apps	No
Financial features	None
Health	No

App access — what it is, and why it matters most

Google runs your app on real devices before approving it. **YNO shows nothing until you are signed in**, so a reviewer who cannot get past the login screen sees a dead app and rejects the release as broken. This is one of the most common rejection reasons, and it is confusing when it happens because the app works perfectly for you.

This section is where you hand them a way in.

- 1 Select **All or some functionality is restricted**.
- 2 Add an instruction entry — name it something like “Email login”.
- 3 Enter the username and password of a test account.
- 4 Write the steps plainly, for example:

Open the app → tap **Log in** → enter the email and password above → tap **Log in**. This gives full access; no invite code or referral is needed.

Use a dedicated throwaway account

Create a fresh account for this and test it yourself first. It must stay alive and its password must not change, or a future update gets rejected.

Do not use `huzaifa@admin.com`. That account can wipe the database from the admin panel, and its credentials are already public in the GitHub repository.

Data safety

Declare honestly — Google cross-checks this against what the app actually does, and a mismatch is treated as a policy violation rather than a mistake.

Data type	Declare
Email address	Collected, linked to identity — account creation
Name	Collected, linked to identity — profile
Photos	Collected, linked to identity — profile and team badges
Contacts	Collected — finding friends already using the app

Answer **no** to sharing with third parties, **yes** to encryption in transit, and **yes** to users being able to request deletion (the app has a delete-account screen).

Contacts gets extra scrutiny

`READ_CONTACTS` is the app's only declared permission. Google looks closely at contacts access: the app must ask for it only when the feature is used, explain why before the system prompt appears, and work without it if refused.

3 Store listing

Grow → Store presence → Main store listing

Asset	Requirement
App name	30 characters
Short description	80 characters — shown first, write it carefully
Full description	4,000 characters
App icon	512×512 PNG — ready at <code>assets/icon/yno_store_512.png</code>
Feature graphic	1024×500 — required even though it is easy to miss
Phone screenshots	2 to 8, min 320px on the short side
App category	Sports
Contact email	Shown publicly on the listing

The support address does not exist yet

The app points at `support@nellab.org`, and that mailbox has never been created. Whatever address goes on the listing must be one somebody actually reads — Play requires a working contact route.

4 Closed testing — the 14-day clock

Test and release → Testing → Closed testing → Create track

- 1 Create the track and upload `app-release.aab`.
- 2 Give the release a name and release notes.
- 3 Open the **Testers** tab, create an email list, add **12 or more** testers.
- 4 Save → Review release → **Start rollout**.
- 5 Copy the opt-in link and send it to every tester.
- 6 **Each tester must open the link and accept the invitation.**

Three ways this clock gets reset

- **Installing is not opting in.** Every tester must follow the opt-in link and accept. Someone who only sideloads the app does not count.
- **Dropping below 12 restarts the 14 days.** Recruit 14 or 15 so one person leaving does not cost you a fortnight.
- **“Continuous” means continuous.** The count is checked over the whole period, not on the last day.

Uploading new builds during the period is fine and does not reset anything — but each upload needs a higher `versionCode`.

5 Production

- 1 After 14 days, the console offers **Apply for production access**.
- 2 Fill in the short form — what you tested, what the testers reported, who the app is for. Answer properly; it is read by a person.
- 3 Wait for approval, then promote the release to **Production**.
- 4 The first full review usually takes a few days and can take longer.

6 Straight after the first upload

Do not skip this — both failures are silent

Google re-signs your app with **its own certificate**, which is different from the key on your machine. Two of its fingerprints must be registered elsewhere, or things break for real users while working perfectly in your own builds.

Go to [Setup → App integrity → App signing](#) and copy both fingerprints of the **App signing key certificate** — not the upload key.

Fingerprint	Where it goes	If missed
SHA-1	Firebase Console → Project settings → Android app	Google sign-in fails for every user from the Play Store
SHA-256	<code>assetlinks.json</code> on nellab.org, then redeploy	App Links stop verifying; referral links open in Chrome

These are additions, not replacements — the existing fingerprints stay. Send both to your developer and the change takes minutes.

7 Things that will bite you

Trap	What happens
Reusing a versionCode	Upload rejected. Bump <code>version:</code> in <code>pubspec.yaml</code> — <code>1.0.0+2</code> , then <code>+3</code> , for every single upload.
Losing the keystore	The app can never be updated under this identity again. It is backed up — keep it that way.
Public admin credentials	<code>lib/admin/admin_config.dart</code> is public with a working super-admin login that can wipe the database. Claim the account and change the password before real users arrive.
Test account going stale	If its password changes or it is deleted, the next update is rejected on App access.
Data safety drift	Adding a permission later without updating the declaration is a policy violation, not an oversight.

8 Order of work

- ☐ Create the app entry in Play Console
- ☐ Create and test a throwaway reviewer account
- ☐ Complete every App content section
- ☐ Produce the feature graphic and screenshots
- ☐ Fill in the store listing
- ☐ Upload the bundle to a closed testing track
- ☐ Recruit 14–15 testers and confirm each has opted in
- ☐ Send the App signing SHA-1 and SHA-256 to your developer
- ☐ Wait out the 14 continuous days
- ☐ Apply for production access
- ☐ Promote to production once granted